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## Some unpublished Linear A documents from Khania

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**Abstract:** During the years 2007 to 2014 a few more Linear A documents were discovered in excavations on the Kastelli Hill at Khania. From the Greek-Swedish-Danish Excavations three fragments of Linear A tablets were found as well as a possible un-inscribed roundel. Two of the Linear A tablets consisted only of two and three sign respectively while the third tablet, KH 104 consisted of three lines where the GRA sign (AB 120) was found in combination with another sign not previously attested in the Linear A corpus. The new roundel from the Greek Katre 1 Excavations, **KH Wc 2124**, is – with an inscription (AB 61) and seal impressions – well-known from Khania. It does, however, display a few unusual features both physically and in the execution of the sign. All the documents are likely to be of LM IB date, even though they were found in later contexts.

**Keywords:** Linear A tablet, roundel, new ligatures, seal impressions, Khania excavations, contexts.

During the systematic Greek excavations in Katre 1, the fragment of a Linear B tablet and two fragments of Linear A tablets were discovered,<sup>1</sup> as well as a Minoan roundel, while the Greek-Swedish-Danish Excavations in 2010 and 2014 unearthed three fragments of Linear A tablets and one possible un-inscribed roundel.

### **KH 102** (GSDE 10-TC 011), Fig. 1

#### Context

This small fragment of a Linear A tablet was, like so many others, discovered among the collected pottery. The context of the fragment is quite clear. It

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1 Andreadaki-Vlazaki & Godart 2014.

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was found in the LM IIIB:1 destruction debris of the collapsed Building 2 in the southern part of Space M,<sup>2</sup> where also **KH 99** was discovered in 2005.<sup>3</sup> The pottery collected from this deposit contained, apart from LM IIIB:1 and LM IIIA:2 pottery, several pieces of earlier date.

### Description

Linear A tablet, fragment of central left part. The clay is very dark grey-brownish and with almost no inclusions. Burnt hard. The tablet is well polished on the obverse and on the edge – less so on the reverse. Obverse upper part has remains of two signs in Linear A and there is no ruler below. The stylus is fine and the incisions light. The fragment recalls the following Linear A tablets from Katre: **KH 32, 49, 80** and **83**. The only unusual aspect is that the edge is not at a right angle to the surface. Width [0.0237]; height [0.0163]; th. 0.0071–0.0055.

### The inscription

*sup. mut.*

.1 AB 08-73[                      1. A-ΜΙ[

*inf. mut.*

### Comment

Of the first sign, most of the left horizontal line is clearly visible in the fracture and there can thus be little doubt that the sign should read AB 08 (A). The remains of the second sign consists of a vertical stroke with the beginning of an oblique stroke to the right, and the most obvious reading of this combination is AB 73 (MI). The sign group 08-73 was previously found twice at Zakros<sup>4</sup> and once at Phaistos(?)<sup>5</sup>, but the incompleteness of the Khania tablet does not permit any further comparison.

### **KH 104** (GSDE 14-TC 008), Fig. 2

#### Context

This tablet was found out of context during the Greek-Swedish-Danish Excavations in Parodos Kanevaro in 2014. It was not recognized at the excavation,

<sup>2</sup> Hallager, Tzedakis & Andreadaki-Vlazaki 2014, 13 and fig. 8.

<sup>3</sup> Andreadaki-Vlazaki & Hallager 2014, 201 and Andreadaki-Vlazaki & Hallager 2007, 13 where the find context at the time of excavation indicated an LM IIIA:2 deposition. The 2010 excavation, however, made it clear that **KH 99** also belonged with the LM IIIB:1 destruction debris.

<sup>4</sup> AB 08-73-0110 on **ZA 10a.3** and AB 08-73-59 on **ZA 10b.4-5**.

<sup>5</sup> AB ]08-73-59 on **PH? 31b.3**.

but was later found among the collected pottery. The context in which it had been deposited was a thick layer of the Geometric period heaped on top of the destroyed Room B of the LM IIIC period (cf. below on **KH Wc 2126**).<sup>6</sup> The pottery collected in this deposit was mainly Geometric, while a few earlier (also LM I) pieces were noted.

### Description

Linear A tablet. Fragment of central left part. Very light brown almost yellowish clay and very finely gritted, except for one small pebble visible at the bottom of the sign PA. The obverse and part of the edge is polished, while the reverse is flaked off. The fragment has remains of three lines with Linear A signs. Fine stylus with light to medium deep incisions. Width [0.043]; height [0.0437]; th. [0.012].

### The inscription

*sup. mut.*

.1 AB 09, 120 , 707 , 03-47[

.2 AB 01-27 , 120+26[

.3 *vest.*

*inf. mut.*

*sup. mut.*

.1 SE , GRA J, PA-47[

.2 DA-RE , GRA+RU[

.3 *vest.*

*inf. mut.*

### Comment

The first sign in the upper line is unmistakably AB 09 (SE), although executed in an unusual way in that the left vertical stroke consists of two isolated strokes: a phenomenon also seen on a few tablets from Hagia Triada.<sup>7</sup> The second sign is undoubtedly the lower part of the ideogram AB 120 which may or may not be ligatured with a second sign as seen below in line 2. Then follows the fractional sign A 707. After this we find AB 03 (PA) with a long vertical stroke crossed by two horizontal strokes in an unusually low position. The next sign appears to be AB 47 executed as an X with a circle in the centre and with one of the strokes slightly curved. The second line starts with the sign group AB 01-27 followed by another AB 120 ligatured with AB 26 (RU). In the third line only two small strokes from the top of a sign is seen.

There is little doubt that this tablet like so many others consists of sign groups (and/or) transaction signs followed by ideograms and numerals.<sup>8</sup> If our interpretation is correct the intriguing thing about the tablet is one of the ideograms. We have interpreted it as a ligature with AB 120, where a second sign has been added,

<sup>6</sup> Hallager & Andreadaki-Vlazaki 2017, 281.

<sup>7</sup> E.g. **HT 6** and **HT 87**.

<sup>8</sup> As for example seen on **HT 128**, cf. **GORILA** 1, 220–221.

while the canonical upper horizontal stroke of the ideogram has been omitted.<sup>9</sup> AB 120 is frequently found together with other signs or fractional signs,<sup>10</sup> but only in two cases, A 573 (120+01) and A 574 (120+03), have they been rendered as one sign like the one on **KH 104**. The combination of 120+26 is thus, on present evidence, a new ligature in the corpus of Linear A. The scribe of this tablet appears to be rather sloppy. The sign group 01-27 is well attested in the Hagia Triada tablets,<sup>11</sup> where it appears mainly in connection with the sign AB 100/102 and always followed by numerals and in a single case also by a fractional sign. It seems therefore most likely 01-27 has an identical meaning as those cases in the Hagia Triada tablets. AB 09 in line 1 must be the ending of a sign group lost at the end of the preceding line, since it never appears as an isolated sign and also because many sign groups in the corpus of Linear A end with this sign. The sign group PA-47 is attested for the first time in Linear A. The sign 47 is not very common as it has previously only been attested eight times, but at five different localities.<sup>12</sup>

### **KH 105** (GSDE 14-TC 038), Fig. 3

#### Context

As was the case with **KH 104**, this tablet – also excavated by the Greek-Swedish-Danish excavations in 2014 – was found among the collected pottery. The tablet fragment was found in a small deposit sealed between two floors of the LM IIIB:2 period.<sup>13</sup> The general area of the find was the Courtyard Area between Buildings 1 and 2.<sup>14</sup> This Courtyard Area had also in contexts of earlier periods revealed LM I administrative documents,<sup>15</sup> and a fragment of a tablet need not surprise us.

#### Description

Linear A tablet, lower left corner of large tablet. Finely gritted clay. Polished all over. No finger prints. Obverse and edge burnt greyish; reverse light brown-reddish. Lower edge has remains from folding of the clay. On the obverse, there are

<sup>9</sup> Even though theoretically possible we do not consider the combination A 326 (= A 120 without upper horizontal stroke) with AB 26 and 27 as a likely solution, since this sign – if not a “misspelling” for AB 120 – looks to be a transaction sign cf. **HT 35.1**, 91.1, **128a.1** and **KH 91.1**.

<sup>10</sup> With other signs: A573-579, and with fractional signs: A580-587, cf. *GORILA* 5, xxv.

<sup>11</sup> **HT 7.a.4**, **10a.2**, b1, **85a.5** and **122b.4**.

<sup>12</sup> Found at Malia, Hagia Triada, Zakro, Knossos and Archanes, cf. *GORILA* 5, 213.

<sup>13</sup> Hallager & Andreadaki-Vlazaki 2017, 285.

<sup>14</sup> For the LM IIIB:2, Courtyard Area in general, see *GSE* III, 86–90.

<sup>15</sup> The roundel **KH Wc 2118** from the LM IIIA:1 deposits; the roundel **KH 2117** from the LM IIIB:1 deposits; and a two-hole hanging nodule from the LM IIIA:2 deposits, cf. Hallager 2016, 386.

the remains of three signs in Linear A. Medium-fine stylus and deeply incised. Width [0.0540]; height [0.0415]; th. 0.0095 (bottom) – 0.125 (top).

The inscription

*sup. mut.*

.1 AB 45-67-37[

DE-KI-TI[

Comment

From the first sign, only the lower part of two incurved strokes are preserved. They are obviously going to cross each other. Given a horizontal line with a “hat” above, the reading of the sign as AB 45 (DE) – as executed on for example **HT 9**, **HT 13** and **HT 31** – is quite possible. The second sign is a canonical AB 67 (KI) as seen on for example **HT 26a** or – if the upper left “addendum” is a circle – as seen on e.g. **HT 8a**. The last sign is a plain AB 37 (TI) apparently without anything between the “legs”. The signs on this tablet appear to be drawn by an experienced scribe. The combination 67-37 (KI-TI) is only found once – on one of the inscribed conical cups from Knossos,<sup>16</sup> but it cannot be part of the same “word” since the sign preceding AB 67 is an AB 01, which is certainly not the case on **HT 105**.

#### **KH Wc 2124** (ME 117), Fig. 4

Context

The Katre 1 excavation has since 2007 revealed some extremely interesting and unique finds for the history of Kydonia, connected to a courtyard of the LM IIIB:1 period. There are indications that this was situated in front of the west entrance to the palatial building of Kydonia. The uniqueness of the finds in this courtyard was the clear from the evidence of the offerings, including scattered bones from a young female human.<sup>17</sup> In the northwestern part of the courtyard – in front of a structure which might have been an altar – the fragment of a Linear B tablet (**KH X 7**) was found and in the upper fill in the same space were the Linear A tablet **KH 101** and the roundel **KH Wc 2124**.<sup>18</sup>

Description

Completely preserved roundel of disk shape. Light red-brownish clay, finely gritted. Smoothed/polished all around. Only a few and vague remains from papillary lines (finger prints). Incisions are medium-deep and the stylus relatively

<sup>16</sup> **KN Zc 6.2**: AB 08-07-01-67-37-03-81.

<sup>17</sup> Andreadaki-Vlazaki 2015.

<sup>18</sup> Andreadaki-Vlazaki in Andreadaki-Vlazaki & Godart 2014, 13.

fine. Obverse inscribed with one sign in Linear A. Part of the lines are almost closed from pressure of fingers, but probably were inscribed last. Along the edge 15 impressions from the same seal. None of the seal impressions are completely preserved. Reading of roundel: vertical with the inscription to the right. Ø: 0.0603 – 0.0570; th. 1.2

### The inscription

Obverse: AB 61; Reverse: empty. Publ. Full bibliography in Hallager 1996 II, 39; and Hallager 1996 I, 114, Table 18.

Seal: Badly preserved impressions from an amygdaloid. Motif two recumbent lions, one behind the other, with the front one looking towards the left and the one behind looking to the right; one slightly bent and one straight stroke in front of the lion looking left. ‘Cut Style’. Publ. Full bibliography in Hallager 1996 II, 39 and further Pini in *GSE* V, 379–380.

### Comment

Both the seal used and the inscription are well documented on other roundels in Khania. The seal was impressed on another 20 roundels found on four different excavations on the Kastelli hill. The 15 found in the Katre 10 excavation are important, since they came from secure LM IB destruction debris and thus give us a good indication for the dating of the roundel. The sign AB 61 was found on ten of the roundels with the same seal impression, while also four other signs were connected to the impression: A 208<sup>VAS</sup> (twice); A 409<sup>VAS</sup> (twice); A 411<sup>VAS(a)</sup> (once) and AB 21 (twice).<sup>19</sup> The meaning of the isolated AB 61<sup>20</sup> remains uncertain, but with this new roundel we now know that the user of the seal had given receipt for receiving at least 85 items of AB 61.<sup>21</sup> **KH Wc 2124** is a large roundel belonging to size category X, of which ten have previously been recorded.<sup>22</sup> These roundels have a very high percentage of used space on the rim: **KH Wc 2124** (like e.g. **KH Wc 2019**) is well above average with 94 % of the space used. The roundel is unusual in that it is rather thin (0.012) compared to others in this size category. The seal has a width of 0.0173 and the thinness of the roundel clearly explains why none of the seal impressions are complete. The sign AB 61 is unusual. Its “cap” consists of one almost straight and one slightly bent stroke to the right, which combination

<sup>19</sup> Hallager 2016, 384–385.

<sup>20</sup> Also found on **HT 113.3** (followed by numerals) and **HT Wa 1279, 1280** and **1281**.

<sup>21</sup> Eight times on 1001; 10 times on 1002; 6+ times on 2034; 2 times on 2035; 7 times on 2101; 10 times on 2104; 10 times on 2105; 8 times on 2110; 3+ times on 2115; 6+ times on 2118; and 15 times on 2115.

<sup>22</sup> Hallager 1996 I, 87.

is found on several other roundels ascribed to Scribe 60.<sup>23</sup> The unusual feature here, however, is that the “internal” bent (or semicircular) stroke is omitted – a feature otherwise only seen on **TL Za 1**<sup>24</sup> and perhaps **PH 19**.<sup>25</sup> Whether this should be considered a variant of AB 61 (with a different meaning) or just an oversight by the scribe remains uncertain. One final and unusual feature about **KH Wc 2124** is that it must have been polished not only originally, but also after it had been inscribed and impressed. This is shown by two features: the missing clear finger prints and the fact that both the right and lower line of the sign had been partly closed by the pressure from the polishing.

### **KH Wc 2126** (GSDE 14-TC 015), Fig. 5

#### Context

A new possible roundel was discovered out of context in the Greek-Swedish-Danish excavations in Parodos Kanevaro in 2014. It was embedded in one of the lower LM IIIC floors (42-Floor 6) of Room B in Building 2 at the position 539.47/712.07/10.75. Room B was in the LM IIIC period a sizable room with two successive hearth/ovens in the centre of the room.<sup>26</sup> The majority of the pottery collected in the floor was LM IIIC, while it also contained some sherds from conical cups of LM I date.

#### Description

Possible roundel. Finely gritted clay burnt dark brown-greyish. Wedge-shaped. One surface polished, the other a little worn. Upper thick edge broken off, but not completely. May have remains from one or possibly two seal impressions, the device of which remains unclear. No finger prints, no inscription. Width 0.030; height [0.028]; th. 0.003 (bottom) – 0.0175 (top).

#### Comment

It cannot be stated with certainty that this “document” is really a roundel. In all its circumstances, it differs in shape from all other Khania roundels with its wedge shape. But roundels of this shape are known from other sites in Crete. It thus recalls **HT Wc 3022**, **MA Wc 13** and **14** – also small roundels with two seal impressions. Wedge-shaped roundels with three seal impressions are also found

<sup>23</sup> Godart in *GORILA* 5, 108.

<sup>24</sup> *GORILA* 5, xxxviii.

<sup>25</sup> *GORILA* 1, 308.

<sup>26</sup> Hallager & Andreadaki-Vlazaki 2017, 282–284, with a plan of the LM IIIC rooms given in Fig. 3.

on, for example, **HT Wc 3013, 3015 and 3019**.<sup>27</sup> The reason why we feel fairly certain that part of a seal impression is preserved is that the clay on this part of the rim is fairly well polished compared to the neighboring fracture. Unfortunately no clear seal device can be discerned. This is unusual, but several parallels can be quoted. It is, for example, the case on **CR Wc 2**<sup>28</sup> and with the roundel recently discovered at Gournia.<sup>29</sup> Furthermore, there can be mentioned a number of seal impressions from Knossos, where the motifs cannot be discerned with any certainty.<sup>30</sup> If a roundel, it belongs to the smaller category (size IV); it can be seen that the seal (as is the case on **CR Wc 2**) is not pressed very deep into the clay since no depression but just a straight line is visible. The area of the impression is ca. 0.012 x 0.012 and there is no part of a rim visible. All this probably means that we are dealing with a relatively large seal with a not too curved surface. Again, if correctly interpreted, the roundel would probably be of LM I date, since the use of roundels on present knowledge did not continue after the LM IB destructions.

### Conclusion

None of the presented documents were found in their original contexts. The physical appearance of the tablet fragments in every case recalls the LM IB tablets from the Katre 10 excavation, and also the roundels are of LM IB date. In other words we are observing largely fragmentary LM IB administrative documents scattered over large areas on the Kastelli hill in Khania. Another three examples have been quoted above in note 11. With very few exceptions from the Greek-Swedish Excavations,<sup>31</sup> this pattern applies to all administrative documents found outside the Katre 10 excavations.<sup>32</sup>

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### Abbreviations

*CMS* *Corpus der minoischen und mykenischen Siegel.*

*GORILA* Godart, L. & J.-P. Olivier, *Recueil des inscriptions en linéaire A*, 1–5 (Études Crétoises 21, 1–5), Paris, 1976–85.

<sup>27</sup> For the roundels referred to, see Hallager 1996 II.

<sup>28</sup> Hallager 1996 II, 9.

<sup>29</sup> Younger 2015, 447.

<sup>30</sup> *CMS* II, 8,2, nos. 611-718, on 727–751.

<sup>31</sup> **KH 88** and **KH 79+89** found in undisputable destruction debris in LM IB House I, Room E, cf. Hallager 1978, 36–38. **KH 90**, **KH 92–93** and **KH 97** were also found in LM IB contexts, but not in their original position and had thus also been moved around after their initial deposition.

<sup>32</sup> See distribution map in Andreadaki-Vlazaki & Hallager 2007, 7, fig. 1.

- GSE The Greek-Swedish Excavations at the Agia Aikaterini Square Kastelli, Khania 1970–1987*, E. Hallager & B. P. Hallager (eds.), Skrifter utgivna av Svenska Institutet i Athen, 4°, XLVII: I–VII.  
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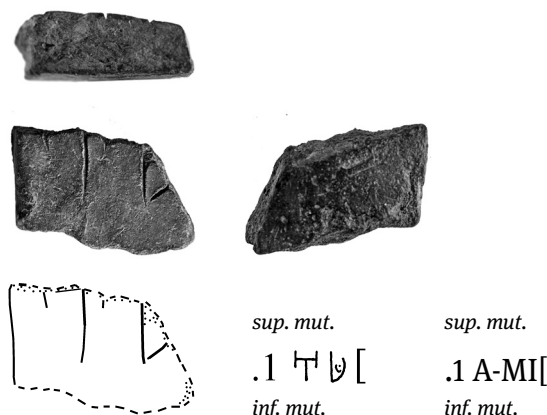


Fig. 1: KH 102, scale 1:1

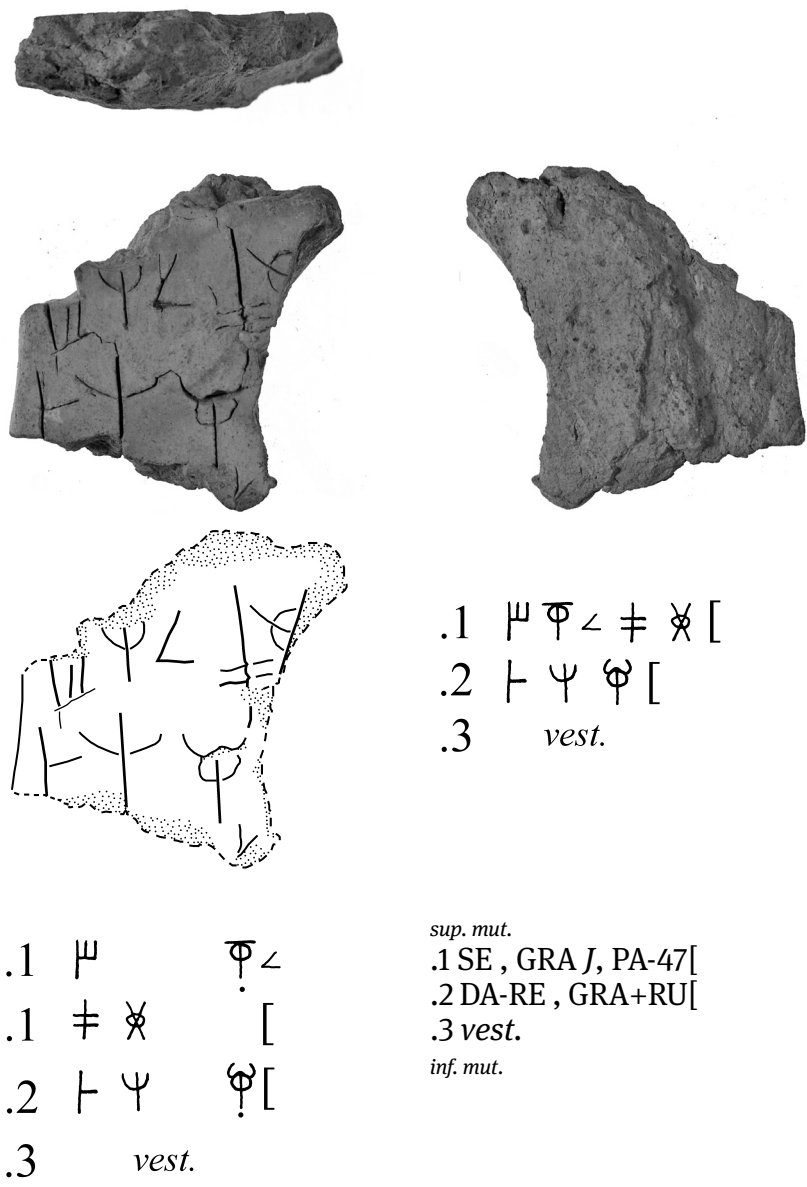


Fig. 2: KH 104, scale 1:1

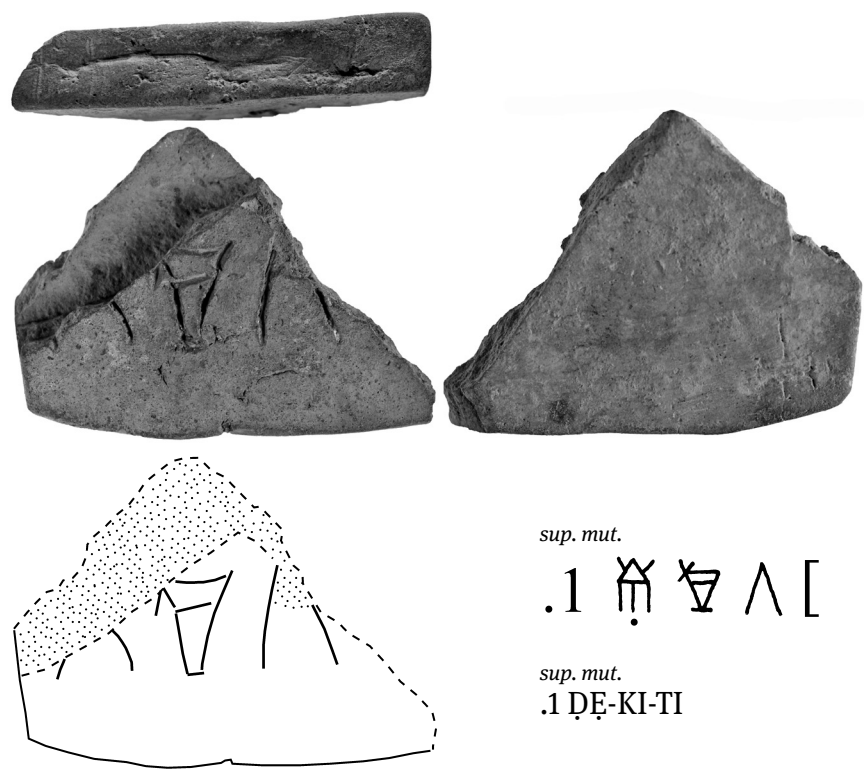
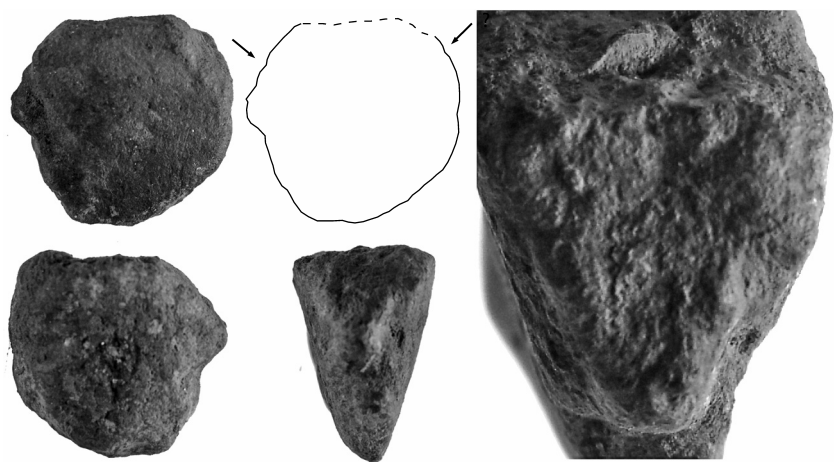


Fig. 3: KH 105, scale 1:1



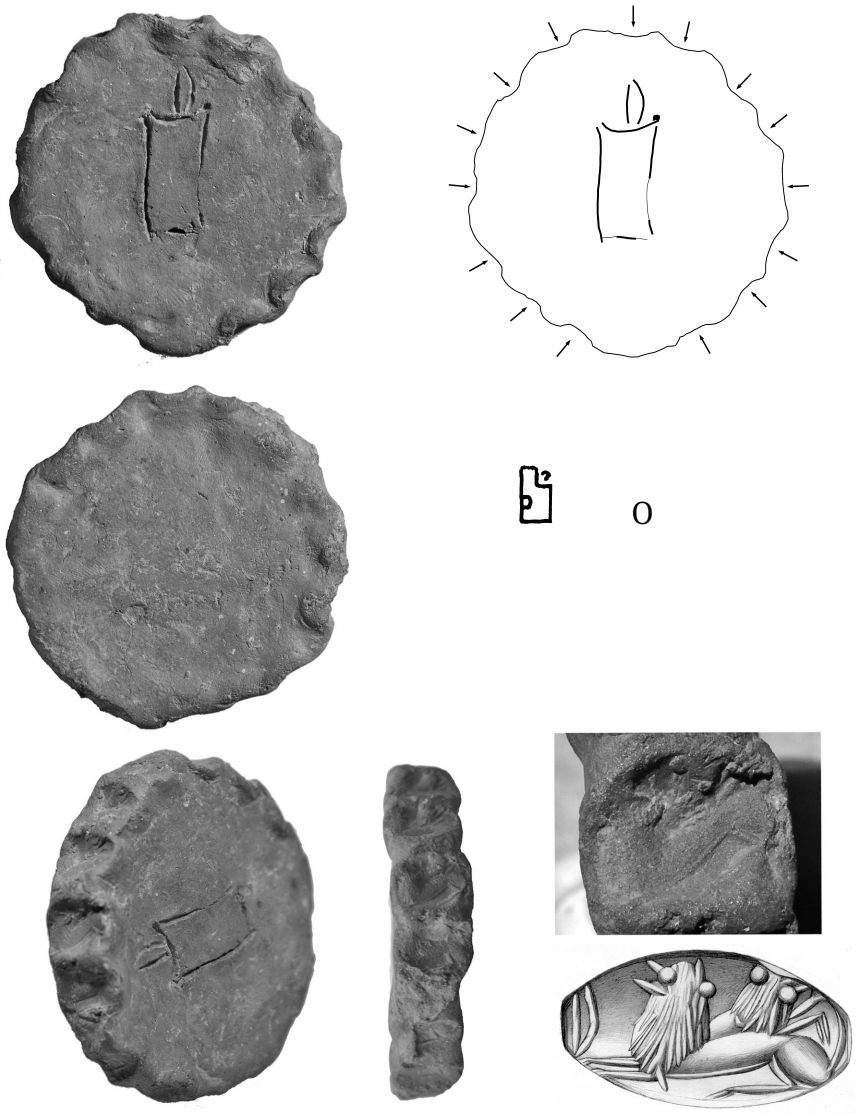


Fig. 4: KH Wc 2124, scale 0.75:1, seal impression 2.25:1